BODHI CLASSES

MODERN INDIA · PRELIMS 2026

# 240 Years, One Clock

From the death of Aurangzeb in 1707 to the midnight of 1947 — every year's events, divided into eight eras, with a war strip, a staircase of Acts and the full line of Governors-General and Viceroys.




IN THIS ISSUE

1. 240 years on one strip
2. The war strip
3. The staircase of Acts
4. Governors-General & Viceroys
5. Eras 1 to 8 — year by year
6. Formulas for chronology
7. Exam traps
8. 20-question practice

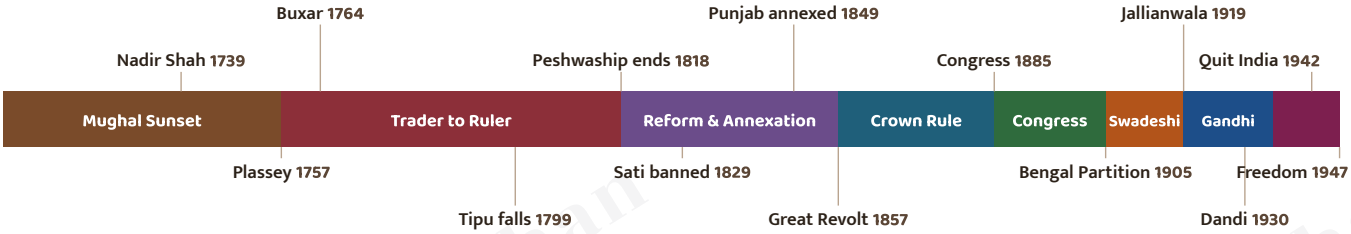
NOTES BY
Aditya Chauhan
aditya31chauhan@gmail.com

# 01 The Big Picture First

Before memorising events, their framework — which era, which war, which law, which ruler.

The biggest enemy of the Modern India timeline is scatter — 240 years, hundreds of dates. The cure is to hang every date on a "peg": which era it belongs to, which war series it is part of, whether it comes before or after a particular Act, and who was in the chair at the time. The four pictures below are exactly these four pegs.

## 240 Years on One Strip




Eight eras — each with its own colour; the chapters ahead follow the same colours.

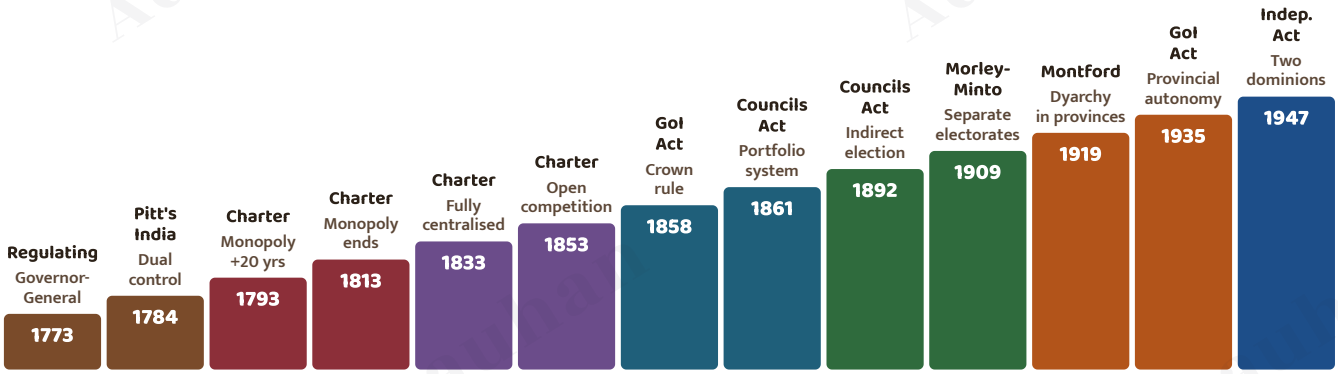
## The War Strip — Who, When, and Which Treaty Ended It

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Carnatic Wars**<br>English vs French | First<br>**1746–48**<br>Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle | Second<br>**1749–54**<br>Treaty of Pondicherry | Third<br>**1756–63**<br>Wandiwash; Treaty of Paris | |
| **Anglo-Mysore Wars**<br>Haidar Ali, Tipu Sultan | First<br>**1767–69**<br>Treaty of Madras | Second<br>**1780–84**<br>Treaty of Mangalore | Third<br>**1790–92**<br>Treaty of Seringapatam | Fourth<br>**1798–99**<br>Death of Tipu |
| **Anglo-Maratha Wars**<br>Peshwa, Scindia, Holkar, Bhonsle | First<br>**1775–82**<br>Treaty of Salbai | Second<br>**1803–05**<br>Deogaon, Surji-Arjungaon | Third<br>**1817–18**<br>Peshwaship abolished | |
| **Anglo-Nepal War**<br>Gorkhas | Only war<br>**1814–16**<br>Treaty of Sugauli | | | |
| **Anglo-Burmese Wars**<br>Burma (Myanmar) | First<br>**1824–26**<br>Treaty of Yandabo | Second<br>**1852**<br>Pegu annexed | Third<br>**1885**<br>Upper Burma annexed (1886) | |
| **Anglo-Afghan Wars**<br>Afghanistan | First<br>**1839–42**<br>Retreat from Kabul | Second<br>**1878–80**<br>Treaty of Gandamak (1879) | Third<br>**1919**<br>Treaty of Rawalpindi | |
| **Anglo-Sikh Wars**<br>Lahore Darbar | First<br>**1845–46**<br>Treaty of Lahore | Second<br>**1848–49**<br>Punjab annexed | | |

### One formula for the order of wars

First the coastal French (Carnatic), then the power of the south (Mysore), then the power of the west-centre (Maratha), then the last wall in the north-west (Sikh) — British expansion moved from the coast inland, and from south to north. Burma and Afghanistan were wars "beyond the frontier".

## The Staircase of Acts — From Company to Constitution




### The logic of the staircase

1. The laws from 1773 to 1853 tighten **Parliament's grip on the Company** — each Charter lasting roughly 20 years.
2. From 1858 to 1892, **direct rule of the Crown** and only token seats for Indians in the councils.
3. From 1909 to 1935, a **slow widening of representation** — separate electorates, dyarchy, provincial autonomy; and in 1947 the transfer of power.

## Who Held the Chair — From Governor-General to Viceroy

### Governors-General of Bengal

1. **Warren Hastings** 1773–85 — Regulating Act, Asiatic Society
2. **Cornwallis** 1786–93 — Permanent Settlement; father of the civil services
3. **John Shore** 1793–98 — Non-intervention
4. **Wellesley** 1798–1805 — Subsidiary Alliance
5. **Cornwallis** 1805 — second term; died
6. **George Barlow** 1805–07 — Vellore Mutiny
7. **Minto I** 1807–13 — Treaty of Amritsar
8. **Hastings (Marquess)** 1813–23 — Nepal War, end of the Peshwaship
9. **Amherst** 1823–28 — First Burmese War
10. **William Bentinck** 1828–33 — Sati abolished, Thuggee suppressed

### Governors-General of India

1. **William Bentinck** 1833–35 — first Governor-General of India
2. **Charles Metcalfe** 1835–36 — liberator of the press
3. **Auckland** 1836–42 — First Afghan War
4. **Ellenborough** 1842–44 — Sindh annexed
5. **Hardinge I** 1844–48 — First Sikh War
6. **Dalhousie** 1848–56 — Doctrine of Lapse, railways, post
7. **Canning** 1856–58 — during the Revolt

### Viceroys (Representatives of the Crown)

1. **Canning** 1858–62 — first Viceroy
2. **Elgin I** 1862–63
3. **John Lawrence** 1864–69 — Shimla, Duar War
4. **Mayo** 1869–72 — financial decentralisation; assassinated
5. **Northbrook** 1872–76 — Kuka Movement
6. **Lytton** 1876–80 — Delhi Durbar, Press Act
7. **Ripon** 1880–84 — local self-government, Ilbert Bill
8. **Dufferin** 1884–88 — birth of the Congress
9. **Lansdowne** 1888–94 — Durand Line
10. **Elgin II** 1894–99 — plague, famine
11. **Curzon** 1899–1905 — Partition of Bengal
12. **Minto II** 1905–10 — Morley-Minto Reforms
13. **Hardinge II** 1910–16 — capital to Delhi
14. **Chelmsford** 1916–21 — Jallianwala, Montford
15. **Reading** 1921–26 — Chauri Chaura
16. **Irwin** 1926–31 — Simon, Dandi
17. **Willingdon** 1931–36 — Poona Pact
18. **Linlithgow** 1936–44 — Quit India
19. **Wavell** 1944–47 — Shimla Conference
20. **Mountbatten** 1947 — last Viceroy, Partition

ERA 1

# Mughal Sunset, Rise of Regional Powers

1707–1756

After Aurangzeb's death Delhi's grip loosened; Awadh, Bengal, Hyderabad, the Marathas and the European companies began filling the vacuum.

**Pivot**
In Delhi the kingmakers (the Sayyid Brothers) became the real power — a weak throne, a powerful court.

**Turning point**
Nadir Shah's plunder in 1739 proved Mughal prestige to be hollow.

**Seed**
The Anglo-French rivalry in the south (Carnatic Wars) gave the recipe of "European troops in Indian rulers' wars".

**1707**
1. Death of Aurangzeb (Ahmednagar); Bahadur Shah I becomes emperor (1707–12) after winning the war of succession.

**1708**
1. Death of Guru Gobind Singh (Nanded); rise of Banda Bahadur in Punjab.

**1712**
1. Death of Bahadur Shah I (February); Jahandar Shah becomes emperor (1712–13) — the historian Iradat Khan called him a "debauched fool".

**1713**
1. Farrukhsiyar becomes emperor with the help of the Sayyid Brothers; Jahandar Shah is killed.

**1715**
1. Sayyid Husain Ali appointed Subedar of the Deccan.

**1716**
1. Banda Bahadur captured and executed in Delhi.

**1717**
1. Farman of Farrukhsiyar — the Company gets duty-free trade in Bengal for ₹3,000 a year and the right to issue dastaks; called the "Magna Carta of the Company".

**1719**
1. Roshan Akhtar Muhammad Shah ("Rangila") becomes emperor (September); treaty between Sayyid Husain Ali and the Marathas (Peshwa Balaji Vishwanath) — chauth and sardeshmukhi in the Deccan.

**1720**
1. Fall of the Sayyid Brothers; Baji Rao I becomes Peshwa.

**1722**
1. Saadat Khan (Burhan-ul-Mulk) becomes Subedar of Awadh — foundation of autonomous Awadh.

**1724**
1. Nizam-ul-Mulk (Chin Qilich Khan) establishes autonomous rule in Hyderabad.

**1739**
1. Invasion of Nadir Shah — Battle of Karnal, sack of Delhi; the Peacock Throne and the Kohinoor taken to Iran.
2. The Marathas (Chimaji Appa) seize Bassein (Vasai) and Salsette from the Portuguese.

**1740**
1. Alivardi Khan becomes Nawab of Bengal.

**1742**
1. Marathas begin raids on Bengal; Dupleix becomes Governor of Pondicherry.

**1745**
1. British naval attack on the French fleet; the Rohillas take control of Rohilkhand.

**1746**
1. La Bourdonnais captures Madras.

**1746–48**
1. First Carnatic War (English vs French) — a shadow of the War of the Austrian Succession in Europe; ended by the Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle (1748), Madras returned to the English.

**1747–48**
1. Ahmad Shah Abdali becomes ruler of Afghanistan; his first invasion of India.

**1748**
1. Death of Nizam-ul-Mulk and of Emperor Muhammad Shah; Ahmad Shah becomes emperor (1748–54).

**1749–54**
1. Second Carnatic War — the English and the French back rival claimants to the thrones of Hyderabad and the Carnatic; Dupleix recalled.

**1750**
1. Death of Nizam Nasir Jung; Muzaffar Jung proclaimed Nizam.

**1751**
1. Robert Clive's siege of Arcot; death of Muzaffar Jung.

**1756**
1. Death of Alivardi Khan; Siraj-ud-Daulah becomes Nawab.
2. Siraj-ud-Daulah captures Calcutta (June) — the "Black Hole" episode.